

Russian, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to Russian

Adhithya Rajasekaran

Starter edition — five cumulative chapters of short lessons.

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Preface

This book teaches Russian one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It assumes no Russian and no Cyrillic. Every section takes one small expression, introduces only the letters, sounds, or grammar that expression needs, connects it to history you may already know, and ends by asking for it back.

Russian is a Slavic language, a cousin of English far enough back that the family resemblance survives in surprising places — *three* is *tri*, *sister* is *sestrá* — and it is worth knowing which resemblances are real and which are traps. This book flags both.

Stress matters enormously in Russian, and ordinary Cyrillic does not print it. So the romanization here marks the stressed vowel with an acute accent, and then gradually yields to the script as you come to read it.

This is a starter edition: ten chapters, complete in themselves, with more being written. Chapters 1 and 2 were written straight into L^AT_EX; chapters 3 to 10 are generated from the same lesson files the audio course reads, so the printed page and the spoken lesson cannot drift apart.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Russian out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real

words from the first page rather than drilling a chart.

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Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings and courtesy	1
1.1 привет (<i>privét</i>) — informal hello	1
1.2 здравствуйте (<i>zdrávstvuyte</i>) — formal hello	2
1.3 спасибо (<i>spasíbo</i>) — thank you	3
1.4 да (<i>da</i>) — yes	3
1.5 нет (<i>nyet</i>) — no, literally not-is	4
1.6 пожалуйста (<i>pozhalústa</i>) — please and you are welcome . .	4
1.7 Chapter 1 retrieval — choose the register	5
2 Introducing yourself	7
2.1 я (<i>ya</i>) — I	7
2.2 ты, вы (<i>ty, vy</i>) — two forms of you	8
2.3 меня зовут ... (<i>menyá zovút ...</i>) — my name is	8
2.4 Ask a name	9
2.5 очень приятно (<i>óchen priyátno</i>) — pleased to meet you . .	10
2.6 A complete formal introduction	10
2.7 The informal switch	11
3 Six Verbs, and the One You Never Say	13
3.1 быт'	13
3.2 зhit'	15
3.3 znat'	16
3.4 govorít'	18
3.5 vídet'	19
3.6 idtí	21

4	Verbs of the Mind and the Page	25
4.1	dúmat'	25
4.2	ponimát'	27
4.3	chitát'	28
4.4	pisát'	30
5	Taking, Asking, Helping, Loving	33
5.1	brat'	33
5.2	spráshivat'	35
5.3	pomogát'	36
5.4	lyubít'	38
6	Water, Coffee, Tea, and Bread	41
6.1	vodá	41
6.2	kófe	43
6.3	chai	44
6.4	khleb	46
7	Friend and Siblings	49
7.1	drug	49
7.2	podrúga	51
7.3	brat	52
7.4	sestrá	53
8	Family	55
8.1	sem'yá	55
9	Eyes, Ears, Mouth, and Nose	57
9.1	úkho	57
9.2	nos	58
9.3	rot	59
9.4	glaz	61
10	Heart	63
10.1	sérdtse	63
	Pronunciation & Cyrillic Reference	65
	Glossary	69
	Review Questions	73

<i>CONTENTS</i>	vii
Answer Key	75
A note on sources	77
Index	79

Chapter 1

Greetings and courtesy

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (6) ✍️ pen (5) 🗣️ **Hands-free start:** first 7 of 12 lessons.

This chapter grows a complete courtesy exchange from six expressions. Cyrillic arrives inside each word, starting with the four letters that most often fool a Latin-alphabet reader.

1.1 привет (*privét*) — informal hello

Read only what this expression needs

Read left to right. In **привет**, **п** says *p*, **р** says *r*, **и** says “ee,” **в** says *v*, **е** begins with a light “ye,” and **т** says *t*. Two shapes lie to a Latin-trained eye: **р** looks like *p* but says *r*; **в** looks like *B* but says *v*. Stress the final syllable: *pri-VYET*.

Where the expression came from

Privét contains the old *vet-* family associated with speaking, news, and counsel. The same family is visible in **совет** *sovét*, a council or piece of advice — the word behind the international name *Soviet*. A greeting and a council both begin with words exchanged.

Use it now

Use **привет** with a friend, child, or someone you already address informally. It is not the safest first word for a stranger in a formal setting.

One-minute checkpoint

Which two letters are false friends? Point to **п** and say *r*; point to **в** and say *v*. Then read **привет** once with final stress.

1.2 здравствуйте (*zdrávstvuyte*) — formal hello**Read only what this expression needs**

This long word is learned as a sound shape before every letter is writable. Aim first for *ZDRAST-vuy-tye*: everyday speech compresses the central cluster and the first written **в** is often not heard. Stress stays near the front. Recognizing a contraction is enough; perfect consonant gymnastics are not.

Where the expression came from

здравствуйте is historically an instruction: “be healthy.” Its core is **здрав-**, the health family also visible in **здоровье** “health.” The ending **-те** is plural and also polite, so the word carries respect in its grammar as well as goodwill in its root.

Use it now

Use **здравствуйте** with a stranger, an older person, a professional contact, or a group. Contrast only the register: **привет** informal; **здравствуйте** polite or plural.

One-minute checkpoint

What wish hides inside the formal greeting? “Be healthy.” Which ending helps make it polite? **-те**. Choose the formal greeting for a new teacher.

1.3 спасибо (*spasíbo*) — thank you**Read only what this expression needs**

Reuse **с** *s*, another false friend because it looks like Latin *C*. The stress is in the middle: *spa-SEE-ba*. The final written **о** is unstressed and reduces toward an *a*-like sound. Russian spelling preserves the word while speech weakens the vowel.

Where the expression came from

спасибо wore down from **спаси Бог**: “God save [you].” English *good-bye* grew from “God be with ye,” and Spanish *adiós* points “to God.” Different languages turned short blessings into ordinary social words; modern *spasíbo* is simply “thank you.”

Use it now

Build a safe formal exchange: **Здравствуйте! — Здравствуйте! — Спасибо.** One greeting and one thanks are enough.

One-minute checkpoint

Where is the stress in **спасибо**? On *-si-*. What happens to final unstressed **о**? It sounds more *a*-like. Say *spa-SEE-ba*.

1.4 да (*da*) — yes**Read only what this expression needs**

Two letters: **д** *d* and **а** *a* as in “father.” Neither is a false friend. Read **да** as one clear syllable.

Use it now

Да is a complete “yes.” Russian also uses it to keep a conversation moving, rather like “right” or “well,” but affirmative *da* is the only job due now.

One-minute checkpoint

Read **да**. Answer a harmless yes/no question with it once.

1.5 нет (*nyet*) — no, literally not-is**Read only what this expression needs**

н is the third major false friend: it looks like Latin *H* but says *n*. At the start of this word **е** carries a “ye” sound, then **т** gives *t*: *nyet*.

Where the expression came from

нет compresses an older combination of **не** “not” and a form of **есть** “is/exists”: roughly “there is not.” The negative *ne* goes back to Indo-European **ne*, a deep relative of English *no*, *not*, *never*, and *nay*.

Use it now

Contrast complete answers only: **да** — yes; **нет** — no.

One-minute checkpoint

What sound does **н** make? Say *n*, then answer “no” with **нет**.

1.6 пожалуйста (*pozhalusta*) — please and you are welcome**Read only what this expression needs**

Meet **ж**, the sound *zh* in English “measure.” The careful spelling is longer than ordinary speech: aim for *pa-ZHAL-sta*. Stress *-zhál-* and allow the middle syllable to contract after you can recognize the full word.

Where the expression came from

The word grew from **пожалуй**, a form connected with granting or doing a favour, plus the old particle **-ста**. That favour-history explains both modern jobs: a request can begin “please,” and a received thanks can

be answered “you are welcome.”

Use it now

Ask with **пожалуйста**; answer **спасибо** with **пожалуйста**. Context chooses between “please” and “you are welcome.”

One-minute checkpoint

What new sound does **ж** carry? *Zh.* Answer **Спасибо** with **Пожалуйста**.

1.7 Chapter 1 retrieval — choose the register

Use it now

For a friend: **Привет!** For a stranger: **Здравствуйте!** Continue either exchange with **Спасибо.** — **Пожалуйста.** Then practise the answer pair **Да.** — **Нет.**

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce: informal hello, formal hello, thank you, you are welcome, yes, no. Now read the six Cyrillic forms in the same order.

Chapter 2

Introducing yourself

Modes: ⇄ voice (9) 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** first 8 of 10 lessons.

The first chapter supplied courtesy moves. This chapter adds pronouns, one naming construction, its matching question, and a complete first conversation. Case appears only through the forms the exchange needs.

2.1 я (*ya*) — I

Read only what this expression needs

я looks like a mirrored Latin *R*, but it is a vowel letter pronounced “ya.” Learn the whole word and letter together: я means “I.” Do not copy the Latin sound onto the Cyrillic shape.

Where the expression came from

First-person pronouns resist borrowing. Russian я continues Proto-Slavic *azŭ, from the ancient Indo-European pronoun family also behind Latin *ego*, German *ich*, and English *I*. The modern shapes differ dramatically because this tiny word has travelled inside each language for millennia.

One-minute checkpoint

What does я say and mean? “Ya, I.” Read it without calling it an *R*.

2.2 ТЫ, ВЫ (*ty, vy*) — two forms of you

Read only what this expression needs

Both words contain **Ы**, a vowel English lacks. Begin with the “ee” of *ill*, then draw the tongue slightly back. **ТЫ** is informal singular; **ВЫ** is plural or polite. The first letters are familiar **Т** *t* and the false friend **В** *v*.

Where the expression came from

English once kept a number and familiarity contrast in *thou* and *you*. Russian still distinguishes **ТЫ** and **ВЫ**. Polite plurals also appear in French *vous*; German formal *Sie* instead uses a third-person form, while Spanish *usted* grew from a title meaning “your grace.” Similar social work can arise through different grammar.

Use it now

Use **ТЫ** with one friend or child. Use **ВЫ** with a stranger, in a formal relationship, or with more than one person. When unsure with an adult stranger, begin with **ВЫ**.

One-minute checkpoint

Choose for one close friend: **ТЫ**. Choose for a new professor: **ВЫ**. Produce the unfamiliar vowel once without turning it into plain “ee.”

2.3 МЕНЯ ЗОВУТ ... (*menyá zovút ...*) — my name is ...

Read only what this expression needs

меня ends in the new **Я** sound; **зовут** reuses **В** *v* and **Т** *t*. Stress the final syllable of each part: *me-NYA zo-VOOT*. Insert the name after the verb: **Меня зовут Анна.**

Use it now

The literal pattern is “[they] call me Anna.” Russian supplies no separate word for “my” or “name” here. The plural verb **зовут** has an unnamed general subject — people call me — much like English “they say it will

rain.” Learn the frame, not a word-for-word English substitution.

Where the expression came from

Меня is the object form paired with subject **я**. English preserves a small version of this contrast in *I/me*; Russian case changes every noun and pronoun. No table is due: notice only that “I” and “me” have different shapes in both languages.

One-minute checkpoint

Does the Russian sentence contain a word for “name”? No. Replace Anna with your name and say **Меня зовут ...** once.

2.4 как вас зовут? (*kak vas zovút?*) — what is your name?

Read only what this expression needs

как is “how.” **вас** is the object form associated here with polite **вы**; **зовут** is unchanged from your answer. Russian asks literally: “How do they call you?”

Where the expression came from

Russian *kak*, French *comment*, and Spanish *cómo* all frame the naming question as “how.” English asks “what” because it treats the answer as a possessed name. The same social question can be organized around an action or a thing.

Use it now

Pair the question and answer: **Как вас зовут? — Меня зовут Анна.** Keep **зовут** exactly the same.

One-minute checkpoint

Which word asks “how”? **как**. Ask the polite question, then answer it with your name.

2.5 очень приятно (*óchen priyátno*) — pleased to meet you

Read only what this expression needs

очень is “very”; its final **ь** is a soft sign, which has no sound of its own but changes the consonant before it. **приятно** is “pleasant.” Read the phrase literally as “very pleasant.”

Where the expression came from

приятно belongs to a Slavic family of favour and affection, traced to Indo-European *preyH- “love, please.” Germanic used the same deep family for English *friend*, a person who is dear; the usual historical account also connects *free*. Russian and English preserve opposite branches of the same old idea.

Use it now

Russian needs no spoken “it is” in this present-tense expression: **Очень приятно.** literally “Very pleasant.” Use it after names are exchanged.

One-minute checkpoint

What does the soft sign pronounce by itself? Nothing. Say the literal two words, “very pleasant,” then the Russian phrase.

2.6 A complete formal introduction

Use it now

Read one turn at a time:

1. A: Здравствуйте!
2. B: Здравствуйте!
3. A: Как вас зовут?
4. B: Меня зовут Анна.
5. A: Очень приятно.

6. В: Спасибо.

Every expression is already known. Only their conversation order is new.

One-minute checkpoint

Cover the list. Rebuild the exchange from these cues: formal hello, ask a name, give a name, pleased to meet you, thank you.

2.7 The informal switch

Read only what this expression needs

Case gives the three pronouns different object forms: я “I” becomes **меня** “me”; ты becomes **тебя**; вы becomes **вас**. Learn these as three pairs, not as a complete case table.

Use it now

With one friend, replace **Здравствуйте** with **Привет** and ask **Как тебя зовут?** The answer stays **Меня зовут ...**; the verb **зовут** does not change.

One-minute checkpoint

Which two pieces change from the formal exchange? The greeting and the object pronoun: **Здравствуйте / вас** become **Привет / тебя**. Produce the informal question once.

Chapter 3

Six Verbs, and the One You Never Say

Modes: 🎧 voice (6) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I do in Russian with six everyday verbs — **быть, жить, знать, говорить, видеть, идти** — put each of them in the **я** form, negate one with **не**, and say a sentence like «**Я — Анна**» the way Russian does, by leaving the verb out entirely.

Say **иду** — «*I am going*», one trip, right now — and hear why Russian splits going-there-once from going-there-often, a distinction English carries in tone and Russian carries in the verb itself. Then place **идти** against the two verb families the chapter has been sorting, and meet the **го-** that English also inherited in *go / went*.

3.1 **быть** — “to be”

Chapter 2 ended on a Russian sentence with no verb in it at all. This lesson is the verb that wasn’t there.

You’ll want to know first — **быть**

быть — *byt’* — to be

Four letters, and you have met all four already: **б** from **спасибо**, **ы** from **ты**, **т** from **привет**, and the soft sign **ь** from **очень**. Nothing new to decode — which is rare, and worth enjoying.

The **ь** is not a sound; it softens the **т** in front of it. That ending **-тъ** is how almost every Russian verb names itself, the way English puts *to* in front.

Grammar Lens: the tense Russian will not say

English: *I am a student.* Russian:

Я студент. — *ya student* — literally “**I student.**”

There is no word between them. Not a short one, not a quiet one — **none**. Russian does not use **быть** in the present tense; you link two things by setting them side by side.

The verb was not lost. Push the sentence into the past and it walks back in: **Я был студентом** — *ya byl studentom* — “I was a student.” The present is the one place it goes silent.

Chapter 1 already showed you the survivor: **нет** is **не** + **есть**, “not-is.” **Есть** means **there is**, never *am*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

быть comes from Proto-Slavic **byti*, from PIE **b^huH-*, “to grow, to become.” Say *byt’* and then say **be** — that is the same root, barely worn.

Its cousins: English **be** and **been**, German *bin*, Latin *fuī* “I was” (which gave English **future**), Sanskrit *bhávati*.

Now the part worth keeping. English *be* is stitched from **three** different ancient roots — *be* from **b^huH-*, *is* and *am* from **h₁es-*, *was* and *were* from **wes-*. Russian holds two of those apart and lets you watch: **быть** is the **b^huH-* one, **есть** is the **h₁es-* one — the same root as English **is**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**быть**” — *byt’*, with a soft final *t*
- “**Я студент**” — and feel the gap where English puts *am*
- the two roots Russian keeps apart — “**быть ... есть**”
- the English pair — “**be ... is**”

Before you move on

Say “to be.” (БЫТЬ.) Now say “I am a student.” (Я студент — two words, and no verb.) Is the verb gone from the language? (No — был returns in the past; only the present drops it.) Which English word is БЫТЬ? (Be — same root, **b^huH-*.) And which English word is ЕСТЬ? (Is.) Next: ЖИТЬ, “to live.”

3.2 ЖИТЬ — “to live”

Last lesson gave you a verb Russian refuses to say. This one you say constantly — and it is the first time you will put an ending on one.

You’ll want to know first — ЖИТЬ

ЖИТЬ — *zhít’* — to live

Same -ть ending as БЫТЬ, and no new letters. The first one, Ж, you met buried in пожалуйста: it is the *zh* of English *measure* or *pleasure* — a *sh* with the voice switched on. English never gives that sound a letter of its own; Russian gives it one.

So: *zhít’*, one syllable, soft *t* at the end.

Grammar Lens: the ending that means “I”

Я живу. — *ya zhivú* — I live.

Two things happened. A -у arrived on the end, and that -у is the whole signal for I — it is what *am*, *do* and *-s* are in English, packed into one letter. And a в surfaced in the middle that the infinitive never showed you: жи-ть becomes жив-у.

That is normal. A Russian verb’s dictionary form and its working stem are allowed to differ, so you learn the pair, not the one.

Switch to *you*, and the ending switches: ты живёшь — *ty zhivyósh* — “you live.” The person lives in the ending; Russian can therefore drop the pronoun entirely and still be perfectly clear.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ЖИТЬ goes back to PIE **ǵʰeih₃-*, “to live,” and the family is enormous: Latin *vīvere* gave English **vivid**, **survive**, **revive**, **vital**; Greek *bíos* gave **biology**, and Greek *zōē* gave **zoo** and **zodiac**.

But the cousin worth carrying is the plain English one: **quick**. It meant **alive**, not fast — the speed came later, from how the living move. It is still frozen in the phrase *the quick and the dead*, in *cut to the quick* (cut to the living flesh), and in **quicksilver**, the metal that behaves as if alive.

So ЖИТЬ is **quick** in its older sense: to be among the living.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ЖИТЬ” — *zhit’*, with the *measure* sound in front
- “Я живу” — and land on the **-y**
- the pair — “живу ... живёшь”
- the old English meaning — “**quick** ... alive”

Before you move on

Say “to live.” (ЖИТЬ.) Say “I live.” (Я живу — and the **-y** is doing the work.) What did English *quick* once mean? (**Alive** — as in *the quick and the dead*.) Name two Latin cousins. (*Vivid*, *survive* — from *vīvere*.) Next: ЗНАТЬ, “to know.”

3.3 ЗНАТЬ — “to know”

The most useful sentence a beginner owns is not *hello*. It is *I don’t know* — and after this lesson you will have it.

You’ll want to know first — ЗНАТЬ

ЗНАТЬ — *znat’* — to know

No new letters, and the same **-ТЬ** that ended **БЫТЬ** and **ЖИТЬ**. Say the **З** and **Н** together with no vowel between them — *zn-*, exactly as English does in the middle of *magnet* but never at the start of a word.

In the present it takes the ending you already own:

Я знаю. — *ya znáyu* — **I know.**

That **-ю** is not a new ending. It is the same **-у** you put on **живу**, spelled so it carries a *y*-glide in front — the same glide **е** carries in **привет**. Russian writes the glide into the vowel instead of adding a letter for it.

Grammar Lens: не, the whole of “don’t”

Я не знаю. — *ya ne znáyu* — **I don’t know.**

You met **не** in Chapter 1, hidden inside **нет** — **не** + **есть**, “not-is.” Here it stands on its own, and it is the entire machinery of English *don’t*, *doesn’t* and *didn’t*: one small word, parked directly in front of the verb, never changing shape.

English needs a helper verb to negate — *I know* becomes *I **do** not know*, with a *do* that appears from nowhere. Russian adds nothing and borrows nothing. Put **не** in front, and you are done.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ЗНАТЬ is PIE **ǵneh₃-*, “to know,” and so is English **know** — the silent *k* in *know* is the fossil of a sound Russian still pronounces in **ЗН-**.

Down the Latin branch: *nōscere* gave **notice**, **notion**, **note**, **ignore** (*not-knowing*), **recognize**, **incognito**, and — through *nōbilis*, “knowable, well-known” — **noble**. Down the Greek branch: *gignōskein* gave **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, **agnostic**. English **ken** and **cunning** come straight down the Germanic branch beside *know*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**ЗНАТЬ**” — *znat'*, both consonants together
- “**Я знаю**” — the **-ю** is your **-у** wearing a glide
- “**Я не знаю**” — and notice you added nothing else
- the family — “**know** ... *notice* ... *ignore* ... *diagnosis*”

Before you move on

Say “to know.” (**Знать.**) Say “I don’t know.” (**Я не знаю.**) What does Russian add to negate a verb, besides **не**? (**Nothing** — no helper verb at all.) Which English word is **знать**? (**Know** — and its silent *k* is the sound Russian kept.) Next: **говорить**, “to speak.”

3.4 говорить — “to speak”

Your first new letter in three lessons, and an English word that looks like a relative and is not one.

You’ll want to know first — говорить

говорить — *govorít’* — to speak, to talk

One letter here is **new**: **г**. It is Greek **gamma** (**Г**) with the corner rounded off, and it says a hard **g**, as in *go* — never the *j* of *gem*.

Everything else you have met. And the two **os** behave the way **спасибо** taught you: an **o** away from the stress slides towards *a*. The stress falls on the last syllable, so this is **ga-va-RIT’**. Russian spells the *o*; your mouth says *a*.

Grammar Lens: verbs come in two families

Я говорю. — *ya gavarýú* — I speak.

The **I** ending is the same **-ю** you put on **знаю**. Every Russian verb in the present ends the same way for *I*. Then switch to *you*, and the two families separate:

- ты знаешь — *ty znáyesh* — you know
- ты говоришь — *ty gavarísh* — you speak

An **-e-** against an **-и-**. That one vowel is the whole difference, and it is why you learn the *you* form alongside the dictionary form: it names the family, and the remaining endings follow from it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

говорить is built on the old Slavic noun *govorъ, “a murmur, a din, the noise of many voices.” Russian still keeps говор for the buzz of a crowd or a regional way of talking. Most etymologists read the root as **imitative** — the word sounds like what it names — which is honest but means there is no tidy English cousin to hand you. Where a root is uncertain, this book says so.

What there *is* to hand you is a trap. **Govern** is **not** related. That is Latin *gubernāre*, “to steer a ship,” from Greek *kybernân* — the same word that gave English **cybernetics** and every **cyber-** since. A governor steers; a говор is a noise. Two roots that never met.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the new letter — “г is gamma, and says *g* as in *go*”
- “говорить” — *ga-va-RIT'*, both *os* leaning towards *a*
- “Я говорю” — same -ю as знаю
- the two families — “знаешь ... говоришь”

Before you move on

What sound is г? (A hard **g**, from Greek gamma.) Say “I speak.” (Я говорю.) Which vowel separates the two verb families in the *you* form? (-e- in знаешь against -и- in говоришь.) Is говорить related to English *govern*? (**No** — *govern* is Greek *kybernân*, “to steer.”) Next: видеть, “to see.”

3.5 видеть — “to see”

One root, two meanings, and half of them ended up in English as words about **knowing** rather than about eyes.

You’ll want to know first — видеть

видеть — *vídet'* — to see

No new letters. Two you should keep honest, though: **В** says *v*, not *b*, and **И** says *ee* — the pair that fooled you in **привет**.

Stress lands on the **first** syllable here — *VEE-dyet'* — the opposite of **говорить**. Russian never prints its stress, so it travels with the word.

The *you* form tells you the family, exactly as promised last lesson:

ТЫ ВИДИШЬ — *ty vídish* — **you see**

An **-ишь**, so **видеть** belongs with **говорить**, not with **знать**.

Grammar Lens: the letter that swaps for “I”

Now the surprise:

Я ВИЖУ. — *ya vízhu* — **I see.**

The **Д** has become **Ж** — the *measure* sound from **ЖИТЬ**. The ending is the ordinary **-у**; it is the consonant in front of it that shifted.

This happens in the **I** form and nowhere else in the present. **ТЫ ВИДИШЬ**, and everyone else, keep their **Д**. So the pattern to carry is small and exact: **ВИЖУ**, then **ВИДИШЬ** — and after that the verb behaves.

English does the same trick and has stopped noticing: *spea*k against *speech*, *break* against *breach*, *bake* against *batch*. A consonant softening beside a front vowel, in both languages, for the same ancient reason.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

видеть is PIE **weid-*, and that root carried **two** senses at once: *to see*, and — because what you have seen is what you know — *to know*.

The seeing branch, through Latin *vidēre*: **video**, **vision**, **visit**, **evident**, **provide**, **review**, **advise**. Through Greek *eîdos*: **idea** and **idol**.

The knowing branch came into English directly: **wit**, **wise**, **wisdom**, **witness** — someone who knows because they saw. Sanskrit took the same turn: the **Veda** is “what has been seen,” meaning knowledge.

Russian kept both halves as two verbs: **видеть** for the eyes, and the older **ведать** for knowing — the *ved-* of *Veda*, still alive in Russian.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “видеть” — *VEE-dyet’*, stress at the front
- the odd pair — “вижу ... видишь”
- which family it joins — “видишь, like говоришь”
- the two branches — “*video* ... *wit*”

Before you move on

Say “to see.” (Видеть.) Say “I see.” (Я вижу — the *д* swapped to *ж*.) Does that swap happen anywhere else in the present? (No — the *I* form only.) What second meaning did **weid-* carry? (To know — hence *wit*, *wise*, *Veda*.) Next: идти, “to go.”

3.6 идти — “to go”

English has one verb for going. Russian has two, and picks between them on a distinction English hides inside its tenses.

You’ll want to know first — идти

идти — *idtí* — to go (on foot, and under way right now)

No new letters, and only four of them. The *дт* in the middle is not really pronounced as two sounds — Russians say *it-TEE*, with the stress at the end.

The endings are ones you already have:

Я иду. — *ya idú* — I’m going.

>

Ты идёшь. — *ty idyósh* — you’re going.

An *-y* for *I*, and an *-ешь* ending for *you*, so идти sits with *знать*, not with *говорить*.

Grammar Lens: going now against going often

Russian keeps a **second** verb for the same activity:

Я иду — I am on my way, **now**, in one direction.

>

Я хожу — *ya khazhú* — I go, **as a habit**, back and forth.

That is not a tense difference. They are two separate verbs, and Russian makes you choose one before you can open your mouth.

English draws the same line with grammar instead: *I'm going* against *I go*. You know the distinction perfectly — you have just never had to choose a **verb** for it. Every Russian verb of motion comes in such a pair, so this one teaches the pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

идти is PIE **h₁ei-*, “to go” — the same root as Latin *īre*, which gave English **exit** (“he goes out”), **transit**, **initial**, **itinerary**, **ambition** (*ambīre*, “to go around” canvassing votes) and **perish** (*perīre*, “to go through, to be lost”).

Now the good part. The past of идти is шёл — *shol* — which shares **no root** with it at all. A verb this common wears out and patches the hole with a second verb; that is called **suppletion**.

English does exactly this. *Go* has no past of its own either: **went** was taken from *wend* and kept. So идти → шёл is *go* → *went*, in two languages, for one reason — the words we use most wear out fastest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “идти” — *it-TEE*
- “Я иду” — on my way this minute
- the contrast — “иду ... хожу”
- the two broken verbs — “идти ... шёл”, “go ... went”

Before you move on

Say “I’m on my way.” (Я иду.) And “I go there regularly”? (Я хожу — a different verb, not a different tense.) What is the past of идти? (Шёл — another root altogether, like English *went*.) Name two English cousins of **h₁ei-*. (*Exit*, *transit* — or *itinerary*.) That

is six Russian verbs, and one of them you will spend your life not saying.

Chapter 4

Verbs of the Mind and the Page

Modes: ⇐ voice (3) 👁 eyes (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I think, understand, read and write in Russian, name the finished partner each of those verbs travels with, and read the letter ш that has been hiding in words I already say.

Say all four verbs of the chapter in the I form — я думаю, я понимаю, я читаю, я пишу — then name each one's finished partner, put the stress on the end of писать where it belongs, and read the ш you have been decoding since живёшь.

4.1 думать — “to think”

Six verbs behind you. This one opens the largest fact about Russian verbs.

You'll want to know first — думать

думать — *dúmat'* — to think

No new letters, and the -ть of знать. Stress on the first syllable, and it never moves: **DOO**-mat'.

Я думаю. — *ya dúmayu* — I think.

That -ю is the one you put on знаю. And ты думаешь — an -ешь, so думать files with знать, not говорить.

Three verbs of the head now: я знаю is a fact I hold, я вижу is what reaches my eyes, я думаю is what goes on behind them.

Grammar Lens: every Russian verb travels with a partner

Russian verbs come in **pairs**. One member is the **doing** — under way, repeated, unfinished. The other is the **deed done**, seen whole.

Думать is the first kind; its partner **подумать** is not “to think” but “to have a thought, and be done with it.”

You have met the instinct once. **Идти** was going *now, one way*, with a separate partner for going *as a habit* — one small family of motion verbs. This is a **different** distinction, applied to nearly **every verb in the language**.

So one job per verb: learn its partner’s **name**. What a pair does to a sentence is a later lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

дума is the Russian noun for **a thought** — and for a body that thinks: the State **Дума** is the lower house of the Russian parliament, this same word.

Its own origin carries a hedge. The standard account makes **дума** an early borrowing from **Gothic** *dōms*, “a judgement” — behind English **doom** (a judgement before it was a fate) and **deem**. If so, **думать** and *doom* are relatives **by contact**, not by descent; a minority prefer an inherited root.

Latin’s *cogito, ergo sum* is built on the same idea, and its other pieces are yours: the **-o** of *cogito* is Latin **ego**, the pronoun Russian keeps as **я**; and *fuī*, “I was,” is **быть**’s root, English **be**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**думать**” — *DOO-mat*’, stress on the front
- the three heads — “**я знаю ... я вижу ... я думаю**”
- the pair — “**думать ... подумать**”, the doing and the done

Before you move on

Say “I think.” (**Я думаю.**) Which family does **думать** join, **знаешь** or **говоришь**? (**Знаешь.**) What is **подумать** beside **думать**, and how many verbs have such a partner? (The **finished** member; nearly

all.) Which English word does the standard account attach **дума** to?
(**Doom**, by borrowing.)

4.2 ПОНИМАТЬ — “to understand”

The most useful sentence a traveller owns is short, and after this lesson it is yours: *I don’t understand*.

You’ll want to know first — ПОНИМАТЬ

ПОНИМАТЬ — *ponimát’* — **to understand**

No new letters. Stress on the last syllable, and both **os** lean towards *a* away from it: **па-ни-МАТ’**.

Я **понимаю**. — *ya panimáyu* — **I understand**.

The same **-ю** as **думаю**. And now the sentence worth more than the rest:

Я **не понимаю**. — *ya ne panimáyu* — **I don’t understand**.

He does the whole job, exactly as in **я не знаю**: one word in front of the verb, no helper borrowed from anywhere. Say those syllables to a Russian speaker and the conversation slows down for you.

Grammar Lens: the partner, and a warning about its shape

Думать took **подумать**: a prefix on the front, nothing else disturbed. Do not expect that every time.

Понимать’s partner is **понять** — same root, but the middle of the word has been squeezed out, **-ним-** against **-ня-**. Russian builds a pair by prefix, by a reshaped stem, or by both, and the shape is learned with the verb.

The job is unchanged: **ПОНИМАТЬ**, **ПОНЯТЬ**, said together, one entry.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

понимать is **по-** plus a root meaning simply **to take**: Indo-European **h₁em-*, which came down the Latin branch as *emere*, “to take, and so to buy.” English took the family whole — **exempt** (taken out), **redeem**

(bought back), **example** (taken as a specimen), **premium**, **prompt**, **assume**, **consume**.

So **понимать** literally says **take hold of**. English says the same and has stopped noticing: **comprehend** is Latin *com-prehendere*, “to seize together”; **grasp** is what a hand does; German **begreifen** is *greifen*, “to grip.”

Set that beside the two pictures Russian already gave you. **Знать** was **ǵnehz-*, English **know** — knowledge you simply *have*. **Видеть** was **weid-*, which meant *see* and *know* at once and gave English **wit** and **wise** — knowledge you *saw*. Now understanding as something you *caught*. And unlike **думать**, which arrived by Gothic borrowing, this one is inherited straight down.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**понимать**” — *pa-ni-MAT*’, both *os* leaning to *a*
- “**Я понимаю**” then “**Я не понимаю**” — one word added, nothing else
- the pair — “**понимать ... понять**”, the squeezed middle
- the picture — “take hold” ... *comprehend*, *grasp*

Before you move on

Say “I don’t understand.” (**Я не понимаю**.) Name **понимать**’s partner and say how its shape differs from **подумать**’s. (**Понять** — the stem is reshaped, not just prefixed.) What does the root of **понимать** mean? (**To take** — as *comprehend* and *grasp* also do.) And which of your knowing-verbs is a borrowing rather than an inheritance? (**Думать**, from Gothic.)

4.3 ЧИТАТЬ — “to read”

English says *I read* and *I am reading* and means two things. Russian cannot — and the reason is a verb it refuses to say.

You'll want to know first — **ЧИТАТЬ****ЧИТАТЬ** — *chítát'* — **to read**

No new letters: **Ч** you have been reading since **ОЧЕНЬ**, and it says the *ch* of *cheese*. Stress on the last syllable, **chi-TAT'**.

Я читаю. — *ya chítáyu* — **I read.**

The same **-ю**, and **ты читаешь** puts it with **знать** and **думать**. Two verbs, one ordinary sentence:

Я читаю и понимаю. — *ya chítáyu i panimáyu* — **I read and I understand.****Grammar Lens: one present tense, two English sentences**

Я читаю is *I read* and *I am reading*. Russian has one present tense and it covers both.

There is a reason, and you hold it. English builds *I am reading* out of **be** plus *-ing*; Russian's **быть** has no present tense to build with — the missing verb of Chapter 3, the one **Я студент** does without. With no auxiliary, Russian never grew the machinery.

The work English does with *am reading* against *read* is carried instead by the **pair**. **ЧИТАТЬ** is the ongoing member; **прочитать** is the finished one — to read a thing **through**, to the end.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ЧИТАТЬ rests on an old Slavic root meaning **to count, to reckon, to heed**, and Russian keeps the family in plain sight: **число** is a *number*, **честь** is *honour*, **почитать** is *to hold in esteem*. Counting, respecting and reading are one act — careful attention, item by item. Outside Slavic the root surfaces in Sanskrit *cétati*, “he perceives.”

And then the trail stops. There is **no secure English descendant**, and the two words that look promising are not it: **cheat** is a clipped *escheat*, from Latin *cadere*, “to fall,” and **chit**, the little note, came into English from India. This book would rather hand you nothing than a cousin that is only a resemblance — the care it took with **говорить**, which is not *govern*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “читать” — *chi-TAT’*, the *ch* of *cheese*
- “Я читаю и понимаю” — and hear it as both *read* and *am reading*
- the pair — “читать ... прочитать”, the doing and the read-through

Before you move on

Say “I read and I understand.” (Я читаю и понимаю.) Give the two English sentences я читаю covers, and say why. (*I read* and *I am reading*; **быть** has no present tense to build the second.) Name the finished partner. (Прочитать.) Which two Russian nouns share this root, and is **читать** related to English *cheat*? (Число and честь; and **но** — as **говорить** was not related to *govern*.)

4.4 писать — “to write”

A new letter, an English family you know on sight, and a stress mistake worth naming before you make it.

You’ll want to know first — писать

писать — *pisát’* — **to write**

Stress on the **last** syllable, **pi-SAT’** — not a detail you may skip.

Я пишу. — *ya pishú* — **I write**, and **I am writing**.

Two things moved: the **с** becomes **ш** in the present, and the stress that sat on the ending for *I* jumps back to the stem elsewhere — пишу (*pishú*), but ты пишешь (*píshesh*). The pair runs as **читать**’s did: **писать** ongoing, **написать** finished.

Careful. **Писать** stressed at the end — *pisát’* — is **to write**. **Писать** stressed at the front — *pisat’* — is a child’s word for **to urinate**, whose *I* form is *písayu* beside *pishú*. The two differ only in where your voice lifts, and beginners land on the wrong one. Stress the **end** and say *pishú*.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Cyrillic.*) All of **писать** is familiar; the new letter arrives in **пишу**.

- **ш** = “**sh**”, the sound of *shoe*. Three uprights on a bar, like a comb with the teeth up.

You have been reading it without being told: **живёшь, знаешь, говоришь** and the past **шёл** all carry it. And note the kind of letter it is: **я** lies to a Latin reader, looking like a mirrored *R* while being a vowel; **ш** resembles nothing Latin at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

писать is Indo-European **peyk-*, “**to cut, to scratch, to mark**” — before ink there was a point and a surface. The root became, in Latin, *pingere*, “to paint”, and English took the results: **paint, picture, pigment**. Russian’s **письмо** (a letter) and **писатель** (a writer) sit on the verb.

That closes the chapter’s thread: **думать** came in from Gothic, **понимать** is a root meaning *take*, **читать** a root meaning *count* with no English descendant, and **писать** a root meaning *scratch* that handed English a wall of paint.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**писать**” then “**я пишу**” — stress on the end, and the **ш** arriving
- the four — “**я думаю, я понимаю, я читаю, я пишу**”

Before you move on

Say “I write.” (**Я пишу**.) Where does the stress go, and what if it goes on the front? (On the **end**; *písat’* is a child’s word for urinating.) What sound is **ш**? (**Sh** — **живёшь, знаешь, говоришь, шёл**.) Say the chapter’s four verbs in the *I* form, then their finished partners. (**Я думаю, я понимаю, я читаю, я пишу; подумать, понять, прочитав, написать**.) And what did **писать**’s root mean? (**To scratch** — hence *paint*.)

Chapter 5

Taking, Asking, Helping, Loving

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I take, ask, help and love in Russian, put any verb I own after **люблю** as a bare infinitive, and tell a suppletive aspect pair like **брать · взять** from an ordinary one like **спрашивать · спросить**.

Say **я люблю** with its inserted **л**, then run every verb you own through it — **я люблю читать, писать, помогать, жить** — and close by naming the chapter’s four partners and picking out **взять** as the one built from a different root.

5.1 брать — “to take”

A short verb, an English cousin you carry every day, and a partner that shares not one letter with it.

You’ll want to know first — **брать**

брать — *brat’* — **to take**

Five letters, all of them yours, and the familiar **-ТЬ**.

Я беру. — *ya berú* — **I take.**

The stem grows a vowel: **бр-** in the infinitive, **бер-** once an ending arrives. Then **ты берёшь**, so this verb sits in the **знать** family, and that **-у** is the plain form of the **-ю** you have been saying.

Three sentences, all ordinary Russian:

Я читаю. Я пишу. Я беру.

Grammar Lens: a pair with nothing in common

The partners so far were recognisable: **читать · прочитать** added a prefix, **понимать · понять** reshaped a middle. Now the hard case.

Брать's finished partner is **взять** — *vzyat'*, **я возьму**, *ya vaz'mú*. Not a prefixed **брать**, not a squeezed one: a **different word entirely**, drafted in as half of the pair.

Grammarians call this **suppletion**, and you have met it once: **идти** takes **шёл** for its past, from another root, exactly as English *go* takes **went**. Here the same trick builds an aspect pair instead of a past tense. There is a quiet reward in it. **Взять** is **вз-** on the very root that built **понимать**, the ancient root meaning *take*. So **брать**'s finished partner is family with the verb for *understand*, and **брать** is the outsider.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

брать is Indo-European **b^her-*, “**to carry, to bear**”, one of the richest roots English owns: **bear, birth, burden, bier**; Latin *ferre* behind **transfer, refer, fertile**; Greek *phérein* behind **metaphor**, a carrying-across. Russian keeps the load too — **бремя** is a burden, and **беременная**, *pregnant*, is literally *carrying*.

Now the trap, because this track flags both kinds. **Брат** means **brother**, sits one soft sign from **брать**, and is **not related**: **брат** is **b^hrét₂ter*, English *brother*. And **быть** is **b^huH-*, English *be*. Three roots that all begin **b^h** — a family accent, not a shared word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**брать**” then “**я беру**” — hear the stem grow its vowel
- “**Я читаю. Я пишу. Я беру.**”
- the odd pair — “**брать ... взять**”, two words sharing nothing
- the other suppletion — “**идти ... шёл**”, “**go ... went**”
- “**брать**” then English “**bear, birth, burden, transfer, metaphor**”

Before you move on

Say “I take.” (Я беру.) Name брать’s finished partner and say what is strange about it, then give the English pair that behaves the same way. (Взять, a different root; *go* and **went**, as идти takes шёл.) Which verb of yours is **взять** related to? (Понимать — both on the old root for *take*.) And is **брать** related to **брат**? (No — different roots, and **быть** is a third.)

5.2 спрашивать — “to ask”

You have asked a question in Russian since Chapter 2 without owning the verb for asking. Here it is.

You’ll want to know first — спрашивать

спрашивать — *spráshivat’* — to ask (a question)

Long on the page, easy in the mouth: the stress lands on **спра-** and stays, **SPRA-shi-vat’**. The **ш** in the middle is the letter пишу introduced.

Я спрашиваю. — *ya spráshivayu* — I ask.

The same -ю, and ты спрашиваешь puts it in the **знать** family. Set it beside your other verb for opening your mouth: **говорить** is to speak, **спрашивать** is to speak with a question mark on the end. And one distinction English hides: Russian asks a **question** with **спрашивать**, but **for a thing** with **просить**.

Grammar Lens: an ordinary pair, after a very strange one

Брать took **взять**, a partner from a different root. That was the worst case, not the norm. **Спрашивать**’s partner is **спросить** — *ya sproshú, ty sprosish* — one root worn into two shapes, the ongoing member long, the finished short.

Why it’s said this way

The moment you ask, Russian makes you choose. **Как вас зовут?** takes **вас** for a stranger and **тебя** for a friend — a choice that sits inside **ты** and **вы**, the split English lost when **thou**, **ты**’s cousin, left ordinary use.

Other languages make the same move by other grammar: French **vous** and Russian **вы** are the plural doing polite duty, German **Sie** borrows the third person, Spanish **usted** grew out of a title.

And recall what that question literally asks: **how** they call you, not what your name is — an action where English reaches for a possession, as French and Spanish also do.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Strip the prefix and **спрашивать** rests on the root of **просить**, “to request”: Indo-European **prek-*, “**to ask**.” In Latin it became *precārī*, “to pray”, and English took the lot: **pray**, **prayer**, **precarious**, **deprecate**. German **fragen** is the Germanic outcome, so **спрашивать** and *fragen* are one inherited word.

English **ask** is not in this family; the cousin kept here is *pray*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “спрашивать” then “я спрашиваю” — and hear the **ш** of пишу
- the two mouths — “я говорю ... я спрашиваю”
- “Как вас зовут” then “Как тебя зовут” — and choose which fits

Before you move on

Say “I ask.” (Я спрашиваю.) Name the partner and say how this pair differs from **брать · взять**. (Спросить — one root in two shapes.) In Как вас зовут?, what decides between **вас** and **тебя**? (Whether the person is **вы** or **ты** — and **ты** is English *thou*.) And give an English cousin of **prek-*. (*Pray, prayer, precarious*.)

5.3 помогать — “to help”

This verb is built out of the word for *being able*, and that word is English **may**. Helping, in Russian, is lending someone your can.

You'll want to know first — помогать

помогать — *potogát'* — to help

The *г* is the letter **говорить** introduced: Greek gamma, a hard **g** as in *go*. Both **os** lean towards *a* away from the stress, as **говорить**'s do — **ра-ма-GAT'**.

Я помогаю. — *ya potagáyu* — I help.

Same -ю, and ты помогаешь files it with **знать**.

One honest limit: the person you help takes a case this book has not reached, so keep the sentence bare. Я помогаю alone is ordinary Russian.

Grammar Lens: a partner that does not end in -ть

Every infinitive so far ended in -ть. The partner of **помогать** does not: it is **помочь**, ending in -чь, and *ya potagú, ty potózhesh*.

A small handful of Russian verbs end that way, and they are built on old roots about power. The shape is a signpost, not an exception to memorise blind.

Three pairs cover the chapter so far: **брать · взять, спрашивать · спросить, помогать · помочь**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

помогать is **по-** plus **-мочь**, and under it sits **мочь**, “to be able” — **я могу**, *ya magú*, “I can.”

That root is Indo-European **magh-*, “to be able, to have power”, and English holds several pieces of it:

- **may** and **might** — the ordinary modal, and the noun for strength in *with might and main*.
- **dismay** — to strip someone of their power to act.
- German **mögen** and **Macht**; and Greek *mēkhanē*, “a contrivance”, which is English **machine** and **mechanic**.

Note what did **not** happen here. **Морь** and *may* still mean the same thing after five thousand years. That is not the usual outcome: **жить**'s root handed English **quick**, which once meant **alive** and now means *fast*. Some roots keep their sense, some drift out of recognition, and

спрашивать's went from *ask* all the way to *pray*. Each one has to be checked rather than guessed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “помогать” — *pa-ma-GAT'*, both *os* leaning to *a*
- “Я помогаю”
- the three pairs — “брать · взять, спрашивать · спросить, помогать · помочь”
- “могу” then English “may, might” — one meaning, two languages

Before you move on

Say “I help.” (Я помогаю.) Which verb is hiding inside it, and what does it mean? (Мочь — to be able; я могу.) Name the partner and say what is odd about its ending. (Помочь, in -чь rather than -ть.) Give two English cousins of **mag^h*-. (*May, might, dismay, machine.*) And which English word from your verbs no longer means what its root meant? (**Quick**, from **жить**'s root — it meant *alive*.)

5.4 любить — “to love, and to like”

The last verb of the chapter is English **love**, and it lets you say every verb you own in a real sentence.

You'll want to know first — любить

любить — *lyubít'* — to love, and to like

One verb for both: with a person, *love*; with an activity, closer to *like*.

Я люблю. — *ya lyublyú* — I love.

And ты любишь — an -ишь, so любить joins говорить and видеть, not знать. The stress moves too: *lyublyú* on the ending, *lyúbish* on the stem.

Grammar Lens: the letter that appears out of nowhere

Любить has no л after the б. Люблю does.

You have met this shape. Видеть swapped д for ж in вижу and nowhere else. Here it happens by insertion: stems ending in б, п, в, м, ф push an л in — but **only in the I form**.

So люблю, then любишь, любят, with no л at all. Learn the I form and the rest behaves.

Grammar Lens: now say everything at once

Любить takes a bare infinitive, as English *like* does — the dictionary form goes straight in:

Я люблю читать. — I like reading. Я люблю писать.
— I like writing. Я люблю думать. — I like thinking. Я
люблю помогать. — I like helping. Я люблю жить. —
I love living.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

любить is Indo-European **leubh-*, and English **love** is the same word — no borrowing, no detour. The family is wider than it looks: **lief**; **believe** (*be-* plus the root — to hold a thing dear enough to trust); **leave** in *by your leave*; and Latin *libet*, “it pleases”, behind **libido**.

Its partner **полюбить** deserves an honest line: not *to finish loving* but **to come to love**, the moment the feeling starts. A pair does not always mean *doing* against *done* — which is why they get a later chapter of their own.

And the root thread: **бр-** carries (*bear*), **-прос-** asks (*pray*), **мог-** is able (*might*), **люб-** holds dear (*love*) — with **пис-** from last chapter still scratching its mark (*picture*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “любить” then “я люблю”, then “ты любишь” without the л
- “Я люблю читать. Я люблю писать. Я люблю помогать. Я люблю жить.”

- the four pairs — “брать · взять, спрашивать · спросить, помогать · помочь, любить · полюбить”

Before you move on

Say “I love”, then “I like reading.” (Я люблю; Я люблю читать.) Where is the л in ты любишь, and which earlier verb behaved this way? (Gone — the insert hits only the *I* form, as д → ж in вижу.) Name the chapter’s four partners, and which is a different root from its verb. (Взять, спросить, помочь, полюбить; взять.) And give the English cousins of любить, брать, спрашивать, помогать and писать. (Love, bear, pray, might, picture.)

Chapter 6

Water, Coffee, Tea, and Bread

Modes: 🗣 voice (2) 👁 eyes (2) 🖱 Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name water, coffee, tea and bread with their genders in Russian, ask for any of them politely, and say which are native and which are loans.

The chapter closes on хлеб, the word that looks native but is a pre-historic Germanic loan: the reader produces all four words with their genders, extends пожалуйста into a real request pattern on кофе and чай, and sorts the set into native (вода), loan disguised by age (хлеб), and two visibly foreign words that arrived by opposite routes (кофе by sea, чай overland). It reaches back to Chapter 5's любить, closing the chapter's own final atoms which nothing had yet revisited.

6.1 вода — “water,” and how every Russian noun announces itself

Five chapters of verbs, and not one noun. Here is the first — and it comes with a rule that will save you for the rest of the book.

You’ll want to know first — вода

вода — vodá — water

Stress on the last syllable, *vo-DÁ*; the unstressed first **o** drifts toward *a*, the same reduction you have been hearing since **спасибо**.

Grammar Lens: no “the,” no “a” — and the ending tells you the gender

Two facts belong together, because each explains the other.

First: Russian has no articles at all. No word for *the*, no word for *a*. **Вода** by itself can mean “water,” “the water,” or “a water” — context carries the difference. Every Romance or Germanic language taught in this program has spent a whole lesson on articles. Russian never will, because it has none to teach.

Second: every Russian noun is one of three genders — masculine, feminine, or neuter — and, unlike Hindi’s arbitrary assignment, Russian’s *ending* usually tells you which:

ending	gender	this chapter’s example
a consonant	masculine	(<i>next lesson</i>)
-а / -я	feminine	вод-а
-о / -е	neuter	(<i>ahead</i>)

Вода ends in **-а**, so it is **feminine** — regular, no exception, the easiest kind of noun this language has. Hold that confidence for exactly one lesson; the next word breaks the rule on purpose.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

вода is Indo-European **wódr*, one of the best-preserved roots in the whole family. English **water** is the same word, barely disguised; so is the combining form **hydro-** in *hydrogen* and *hydrate*, which English borrowed separately from the Greek branch of the same root.

Russian kept building on it at home, too: **vódka** is **вод-а** plus the affectionate diminutive **-ка** — literally “**little water**.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**вода**” — *vo-DÁ*, stress on the end
- the three endings — “consonant, masculine; **-а** or **-я**, feminine; **-о** or **-е**, neuter”
- “water, hydro-, **vódka**” — one root, three words you already own

Before you move on

Say “water.” (Вода.) What two words does Russian have for “the” and “a”? (**Neither exists.**) What ending makes вода feminine, and what are the other two endings for? (-а; a consonant for masculine, -о or -е for neuter.) Name two English words from the same root as вода. (**Water, hydro-** — and Russian’s own **vódka**, “little water.”)

6.2 кофе — “coffee,” the noun that breaks the rule you just learned

Last lesson’s rule said -о and -е endings are neuter. This word ends in -е and is not neuter at all — meet Russian’s most argued-about noun.

You’ll want to know first — кофе

кофе — *kófe* — coffee. **Masculine.**

Say that twice: **masculine**, ending in -е. By last lesson’s rule it should be neuter, like every other -е noun ahead in this book. It never declines at all — кофе is **indeclinable**, the identical shape in every sentence, so there is no ending left to fix.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Cyrillic.*) One new letter: ф.

- ф = “f” — Greek **phi** (Φ), a circle with a line through it. You have already met two other Greek-shaped letters, γ (gamma) and λ (lambda); ф joins them.

Everything else in кофе — к, о, е — you have read since Chapter 1.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

кофе is a loanword, and a recent one beside вода’s prehistoric root. It travelled **Arabic** *qahwa* → **Ottoman Turkish** *kahve* → **Dutch** *koffie*, and reached Russian during Peter the Great’s westernizing reforms in the early 1700s — the same push that filled Russian with borrowed Dutch and German trade and technical vocabulary.

Its first Russian form was **кофий**, ending like an ordinary masculine noun (compare **чай**, next lesson). Across the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries the final syllable wore down to today's **кофе** — but the **gender stuck**, long after the ending that explained it was gone. Dictionaries still mark it masculine; everyday speech increasingly treats it as neuter, exactly the way last lesson's rule would predict, and the argument between the two is still alive in Russian classrooms today.

You already own the verb for how you feel about it:

Я люблю кофе. — *ya lyublyú kófe* — **I love coffee.**

(**Кофе** is inanimate and masculine, so it takes exactly the same shape here as it does standing alone — nothing to adjust.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**кофе**” — masculine, indeclinable, never changes shape
- the new letter — “**ф** is phi, and says f”
- the route — “qahwa, kahve, koffie, **кофе**”
- “Я люблю кофе.”

Before you move on

Say “coffee,” with its gender. (**Кофе** — **masculine**.) Why is that surprising, given last lesson's rule? (**It ends in -e**, which the rule predicts as neuter.) Name the three languages the word crossed before Russian, and the century it arrived. (**Arabic, Turkish, Dutch; the early 1700s.**) Say “I love coffee.” (Я люблю кофе.)

6.3 чай — “tea,” which went overland while кофе went by sea

Same drink family, a completely different journey — and, finally, the sentence that actually orders one.

You'll want to know first — чай

чай — *chai* — tea. Masculine.

A consonant ending, so last lesson's rule holds without a fight this time: consonant-final nouns are masculine, and чай is the plain case. Every letter — ч, а, й — you have read since Chapter 2.

*(Careful on paper: romanized, this word looks like the English drink brand name **chai** and nothing else — pure coincidence of spelling, not a shared history. Its real cousins are below.)*

Grammar Lens: asking politely, at last

You have owned **пожалуйста** since Chapter 1 and had nothing new to attach it to. Now you do: name the thing, add the word.

Чай, пожалуйста. — *chai, pazhálusta* — Tea, please.

Кофе, пожалуйста. — *kófe, pazhálusta* — Coffee, please.

Both words sit here exactly as they do alone — чай is already the shape a request needs, and кофе never changes shape at all. That is not an accident of this chapter: it is the simplest version of a pattern you will meet in its fuller, case-shifting form once this book reaches nouns that *do* change for a request. For now, name the thing, add **пожалуйста**, and you are understood.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

чай is Mandarin Chinese **chá**, and it reached Russia by the opposite road from кофе. Persian traders on the Silk Road bought it from northern China as *cha-ye khatai*, “tea of Cathay,” and their Turkic-speaking customers misheard the trailing syllable as part of the word itself — giving **Turkish çay**, **Persian chāy**, and, at the end of the same overland chain, **Russian чай**.

Compare last lesson's кофе: **Arabic** → **Turkish** → **Dutch**, by ship, arriving in Peter the Great's Russia from the west. Чай came **overland**, **from the east**, along a caravan route that also carried it into Hindi (*chai*) and Arabic (*shai*). One plant; two words for it in English (**tea** took the same Chinese root by sea, through Dutch traders on the coast) — and Russian happens to have picked the **eastern** branch, while English picked the **southern coastal** one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “чай” — one syllable, masculine
- “Чай, пожалуйста. Кофе, пожалуйста.”
- the fork — “chá overland to chai; chá by sea to tea”

Before you move on

Say “tea,” with its gender. (Чай — **masculine**.) Ask for it politely. (Чай, пожалуйста.) Which route did чай travel, and which did кофе travel? (Чай: overland, Chinese → Persian → Turkic → Russian. Кофе: by sea, Arabic → Turkish → Dutch → Russian.) Which English word took the same Chinese root as чай, but by the other route? (Tea — by sea, through Dutch.)

6.4 хлеб — “bread,” the chapter’s fourth word and its only immigrant besides кофе

One more request word, one more letter, and then the whole table — four things to ask for, and what each one’s history actually is.

You’ll want to know first — хлеб

хлеб — *khleb* — bread. Masculine.

Consonant-final, so the ending rule holds again. And the pattern from last lesson still works:

Хлеб, пожалуйста. — *khleb, pazhálusta* — Bread, please.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Cyrillic.*) One new letter: х.

- х = a raspy “**kh**,” made where you’d clear your throat — not the hard *k* of кофе’s к. It **looks like Latin x** and says nothing like it: a fourth false friend, alongside в, р, с, н from Chapter 1.

л, е, б you already have. Keep х apart from last lesson’s ф: one is a throat rasp, the other a clean *f*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is the twist this chapter has been building to. **хлеб** looks and sounds completely native — nothing about it announces itself as foreign the way **кофе** or **чай** do. But it is a **borrowing**, and an ancient one: Proto-Slavic took it from **Proto-Germanic *hlaibaz**, the same root that gave English **loaf** and German **Laib**. It happened so far back in prehistory — long before **кофе**’s eighteenth century or **чай**’s Silk Road centuries — that the word has had well over a thousand years to stop feeling borrowed at all.

So the chapter’s four words sort into a pattern worth naming outright:

word	route	age
вода	inherited straight from PIE	prehistoric, native
кофе	Arabic → Turkish → Dutch, by sea	18th century
чай	Chinese → Persian → Turkic, overland	centuries old
хлеб	Germanic *hlaibaz	prehistoric, but borrowed

Вода and **хлеб** both feel completely native — but only one of them actually is. Age can disguise a loanword as thoroughly as it can preserve an inheritance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “хлеб” — the raspy х, masculine
- “Хлеб, пожалуйста.”
- all four requests — “Вода, кофе, чай, хлеб, пожалуйста” — one request word covering the whole table
- “Я люблю хлеб.” — the same pattern that closed **кофе**’s lesson

Before you move on

Say “bread,” with its gender, and ask for it politely. (Хлеб — **masculine**; Хлеб, пожалуйста.) What does **x** sound like, and which Latin letter does it impersonate? (A raspy **kh**; looks like **x**.) Which of this chapter’s four words is native, which is borrowed but looks native, and which two are visibly foreign? (Вода native; хлеб borrowed from Germanic but disguised by age; кофе and чай, both visibly loans, by opposite routes.) Say “I love bread,” recalling the verb Chapter 5 ended on. (Я люблю хлеб — люблю, with its inserted л.)

Chapter 7

Friend and Siblings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a friend, brother and sister in Russian, build a feminine person-noun with **по-...-а**, and say which pronoun, **ты** or **вы**, goes with each.

*The chapter closes on **сестра**, **брат**'s securely cognate pair: the reader produces **друг**, **подруга**, **брат** and **сестра** with their genders, builds the **по-...-а** feminine pattern on **подруга**, and names all four as exactly who Chapter 2's **ты** was for. It reaches back to Chapter 5's **братъ/брат** minimal pair and rescues three Chapter 2 atoms — the **ты/вы** comparison, the *vy*-politeness pragmatics, and the *ty*/thou etymology — that nothing had revisited since.*

7.1 друг — “friend,” the word that explains why ты exists

A new chapter, and the first word in it names exactly who Chapter 2's informal **ты** was built for.

You'll want to know first — **друг**

друг — *drug* — **friend** (a man, or a friend generally)

Consonant-final, so masculine — the ending rule holding steady for the third time. Every letter is one you already read — none of them the throat-rasp **х** that **хлеб** just taught you; that one waits for a later word.

(Romanized, this word is spelled exactly like the English **drug** — pure accident of transliteration, no shared root at all. Say it drook-ish, not like the English word it happens to resemble on the page.)

This is the noun Chapter 2’s whole **ТЫ/ВЫ** choice was about. **ТЫ** is for a **друг** — someone close enough that formality would feel wrong. **ВЫ** is for the stranger, the elder, the shopkeeper: everyone **друг** does not cover.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

друг is Indo-European **d^hrewg^h-*, “to accompany, to be loyal” — a companion-on-the-road sense, not far from **друг**’s meaning today. Its clearest descendants sit outside everyday modern English: Gothic **gadrauhts**, “warrior” (literally one who accompanies), and Old English **dryhten**, “lord” — originally the leader a troop of *drauhts* followed, a word that survives only in old poetry now, not in ordinary speech. Unlike **хлеб**’s tidy modern cousin *loaf*, this is a root that mostly vanished from English rather than one that thrived in it — worth saying plainly rather than stretching for a connection that isn’t really there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**друг**” — masculine, consonant ending
- the pair — “**ТЫ** for a **друг**, **ВЫ** for everyone else”
- the false friend on paper — “drug, spelled like the English word, unrelated to it”
- last chapter’s letter — “**х**, the throat-rasp from **хлеб**”

Before you move on

Say “friend.” (**Друг**.) Which pronoun goes with a **друг**, and which is for everyone else? (**ТЫ** for a friend; **ВЫ** otherwise.) What did **друг**’s root originally mean? (**To accompany, to be loyal** — Gothic *gadrauhts*, “warrior”; English *dryhten*, now archaic.) Is **друг** related to the English word it looks like on the page? (**No** — pure spelling coincidence.) And what English word is **хлеб**’s modern cousin? (**Loaf**.)

7.2 подруга — “friend” (female), built on the word you just learned

Russian doesn’t reach for a new word to make друг feminine — it builds one, in front of your eyes, out of pieces you already have.

You’ll want to know first — подруга

подруга — *podrúga* — **friend** (a woman)

Ends in **-a**, so feminine — the rule holding for the second time in this chapter, this time on a longer word.

Grammar Lens: watch the word get built

Take друг apart and put it back together:

по- (a prefix here worn down to little independent meaning)
+ друг (friend) + -a (the feminine ending) → подруга

This is Russian’s ordinary machinery for turning a masculine person-word feminine: keep the root, change the ending, sometimes add a light prefix along the way. It is the same instinct English uses in *host* → *host-ess* or *actor* → *actr-ess* — a suffix doing the work — except Russian reaches for this pattern constantly, on ordinary words, not just a formal handful.

Say the pair together and the family resemblance is obvious:

друг · подруга — *drug* · *podrúga*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “подруга” — feminine, stress on the second syllable
- the build — “по- plus друг plus -a”
- the pair — “друг, подруга”

Before you move on

Say “friend” for a woman. (Подруга.) What three pieces build it, and what does each contribute? (По- + друг + -а, the feminine ending.) What English pattern does the same job, on different words? (-ess, as in *host/hostess*.) And what does друг itself trace back to? (PIE *d^hrewg^h-*, “to accompany, be loyal.”)

7.3 брат — “brother,” the noun Chapter 5 already warned you about

Chapter 5 told you брат meant “brother” and was **not** related to the verb брать, “to take” — a warning, in passing, about a word not yet properly taught. Here it is, properly taught.

You’ll want to know first — брат

брат — *brat* — **brother**. Masculine.

Consonant-final, so the ending rule holds a fourth time. And here is the minimal pair Chapter 5 flagged: брат (brother) against брать (to take, romanized *brat’*) — one soft sign, and nothing else, separates them. Say *brat* with a hard final *t* for “brother”; *brat’* with a soft one for “to take.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

брат is Indo-European **b^hréh₂tēr* — and this time the resemblance to English is not a trap but the real thing: **brother** is the same word, inherited, not borrowed. So is Latin **frāter** (→ **fraternal**, **fraternity**), and Sanskrit **bhrātar**. Few words in any language family are reconstructed with as much confidence as this one.

Recall Chapter 5’s other two **b^h-* words, because the three sit right next to each other and mean three different things: брать (**b^her-*, “to carry” → **bear**, **birth**), быть (**b^huH-*, “to be” → English **be**), and now брат (**b^hréh₂tēr*, “brother”). Three roots, one shared opening sound, no shared meaning — a family accent, not a family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “брат” — hard final t, brother
- the minimal pair — “брат, брать” — one soft sign apart
- “brother, frāter, bhrātar” — the same word, three languages
- the chapter so far — “друг, подруга, брат”

Before you move on

Say “brother.” (Брат.) What one sound separates it from брать, “to take”? (A **soft sign** — none in брат, one in брать.) Is брат’s resemblance to English **brother** real or a trap? (**Real** — inherited, like Latin *frāter* and Sanskrit *bhrātar*.) Name Chapter 5’s two other **b^h-* words, and what each one means. (Быть, “to be”; брать, “to take” — three different roots, one shared sound.)

7.4 сестра — “sister,” and the chapter closes on four people

Брат’s partner, one more secure cognate, and the four people this chapter has introduced you to, gathered in one place.

You’ll want to know first — сестра

сестра — *sestrá* — **sister. Feminine.**

Ends in **-a**, stress on the end: *ses-TRÁ*. Say брат and сестра together and you have both siblings, both genders’ endings, in one breath.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

сестра is Indo-European **swésōr* — and, like брат, this is a straight inheritance, not a loan and not a false lead. English **sister** is the same word (by way of Old Norse, reinforcing an Old English form that had drifted further); Latin’s version, **soror**, took a bumpier sound-change road to the same root. Brother and sister arrive as a matched pair in Russian exactly as they do in the deep history of the whole family.

Grammar Lens: who gets ты

Chapter 2 gave you **ты** for someone close and **вы** for everyone else — the same choice English used to make with **thou** and **you**, before *thou* died out and *you* took over both jobs. This chapter has now named exactly who sits on the **ты** side of that line: a **друг**, a **подруга**, a **брат**, a **сестра** — the people close enough that formality would be strange. Everyone else still gets **вы**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**сестра**” — feminine, stress on the end
- the pair — “**брат, сестра**” — brother, sister
- the four people — “**друг, подруга, брат, сестра**”
- “sister, soror” — same root, one smooth, one bumpy

Before you move on

Say “sister,” with its gender. (**Сестра** — **feminine**.) Is its resemblance to English **sister** real? (**Yes** — both from PIE **swésōr*.) Name all four people this chapter taught, and which pronoun goes with every one of them. (**Друг, подруга, брат, сестра** — all **ты**.) What pair of English words used to make the same close/distant choice Russian’s **ты/вы** still makes? (**Thou** and **you**.)

Chapter 8

Family

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a family in Russian, and say what its own root shares with the English word home.

A one-lesson chapter that gathers Chapter 7's four people under семья, and reaches all the way back to Chapter 3's ЖИТЬ to rescue that lesson's stranded etymon — the two words share an idea, if not a root, and the chapter says so honestly.

8.1 семья — “family,” the word that gathers the chapter before it

One word to hold everyone Chapter 7 introduced — and a root that turns out to be hiding an English word you use every day.

You'll want to know first — семья

семья — *sem'yá* — family

The soft sign softens the м; stress lands on the final -я, so it rhymes with друг · подруга · брат · сестра — this is the word that gathers all four of them.

(Note the ending: -ья is a soft-consonant variant of -я, and still counts as the regular feminine ending from Chapter 6's rule.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

семья is Indo-European **key-*, “to lie down, to settle” — the same root that, through the Baltic branch, gave Lithuanian *šeimà*, “family,” and Ancient Greek *kōmē*, “village.” That is already a wide family. But it goes one branch further: through **Proto-Germanic** **haimaz*, “home, village,” the very same root became English **home** — and, in its diminutive form, **hamlet** — and it survives fossilized in every English place name ending in **-ham**: *Birmingham*, *Nottingham*, *Durham*. Settle somewhere, and Slavic calls the people you settled with your **семья**; the deep Germanic cousin of that same root calls the place itself your *home*. Chapter 3 taught you **жить**, “to live” — a different root (PIE **g^weyh₃-*, the one behind English *quick* in its old sense of “alive”), but the same idea from a different angle: **семья** is who you settle with; **жить** is what you do once you’re there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**семья**” — soft **м**, stress on **-я**
- the four it gathers — “**друг, подруга, брат, сестра — моя семья**” in idea, if not yet in Russian grammar
- the cousin — “*key-* settle → **семья**, and → home, hamlet, **-ham**”
- “**семья, жить**” — who you settle with, and what you do there

Before you move on

Say “family.” (**Семья**.) What English word is its distant Germanic cousin, and what three English place-name endings preserve the same root? (**Home** — and every **-ham** place name: *Birmingham*, *Nottingham*, *Durham*.) Which earlier verb shares the same idea, if not the same root, and what did that verb’s own root originally mean? (**Жить**, “to live” — PIE for “quick, alive.”) Name the four people **семья** gathers. (**Друг, подруга, брат, сестра**.)

Chapter 9

Eyes, Ears, Mouth, and Nose

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the ear, nose, mouth and eye in Russian with their genders, and say which trace to a secure ancient root and which do not.

The chapter closes on глаз, the word that quietly evicted Russian's true inherited eye-word: the reader produces all four face words with their genders, names ухо and нос as secure PIE cognates, names рот as an honest dead end, and traces глаз back to slang for 'ball' while placing the real cousin of English eye, око, inside очки. It is the first realization of SPINE-CHECK-WELLBEING in this track, and it reaches back to Chapter 3's видеть and говорить, rescuing three atoms nothing had revisited.

9.1 yxo — “ear,” and Russian’s third gender finally arrives

A new chapter, a new part of the body, and the last of Chapter 6’s three genders — held back until now, on purpose.

You’ll want to know first — yxo

yxo — *úkho* — ear. Neuter.

Stress on the first syllable: *Úkho*. Ends in -o, so — finally — Chapter 6’s third row: **-o and -e mark the neuter**, and here is the first word in this book to actually wear it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

yxo is Indo-European **h₂ous-*, and the cousin web is about as tight as this book gets: English **ear** is the same word; so is Latin **auris** (→ **auricle**, **aural**), and Greek **ous** (→ **otitis**, an ear infection). Four languages, one unbroken thread from a single ancient root — no borrowing, no replacement, nothing lost along the way.

That makes **yxo** the plainest kind of cousin in this book: not a loanword like **κοφε**, not a word that replaced an older one, just the same PIE root worn down four different ways in four different mouths.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**yxo**” — stress on the front, neuter
- the third row — “-o and -e, neuter”
- “ear, auris, ous” — one root, three languages

Before you move on

Say “ear.” (**yxo**.) What gender is it, and which ending finally shows it? (**Neuter** — -o.) Name two other languages that share the same root word for “ear.” (**English ear**, **Latin auris** — also Greek *ous*.) Is this word borrowed or inherited? (**Inherited**, straight from PIE, no detour.)

9.2 HOC — “nose,” a second straight cousin in a row

One syllable, one gender back to consonant-final masculine, and another word that never left the family.

You’ll want to know first — HOC

HOC — *nos* — **nose**. **Masculine**.

Consonant-final, back to the first row of Chapter 6’s table. Every letter is one you have read since Chapter 1.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

HOC is Indo-European **nas-*, and it barely needs translating: English **nose** is the same word, and so is Latin **nasus** (→ **nasal**, **nasturtium**, the “nose-twisting” flower). Say *nos* next to *nose* and *nasus* and the family resemblance needs no explaining at all.

Two body-part words in a row, **YXO** and **HOC**, and both are the same kind of cousin: no loan, no replacement, just the same ancient root, worn down along three different paths to the same meaning.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**HOC**” — one syllable, masculine
- “nose, nasus” — barely disguised
- the pair so far — “**YXO**, **HOC**”

Before you move on

Say “nose,” with its gender. (**HOC** — **masculine**.) Name its two closest cousins. (**English nose**, **Latin nasus**.) What English flower name comes from the Latin cousin? (**Nasturtium**.) Which earlier word in this chapter is the same kind of straight inheritance? (**YXO**, “ear.”)

9.3 pot — “mouth,” where the cousin trail actually runs out

Two straight cousins in a row was good luck, not the rule. This one has no secure English relative at all — and it belongs to a verb you already own.

You’ll want to know first — **pot**

pot — *rot* — **mouth**. Masculine.

Consonant-final, masculine again. (*On paper this romanizes exactly like the English word **rot** — another spelling coincidence, like друг/drug, with no shared history at all.*)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Ухо and нос both handed you a clean English cousin. рот does not. Its Proto-Slavic ancestor *рътъ originally meant “beak, snout” and is **probably** related to рыть, “to dig, to burrow” — the picture of an animal’s snout rooting through the ground, later widened to any mouth, including yours. There is **no secure link to English *mouth*** at all: English’s word comes from an entirely separate Germanic root, *munþaz, with no shared ancestor here. Where Chapter 4’s читать had no English descendant, this word has no English *ancestor* in common — a different kind of dead end, and worth naming exactly that plainly rather than forcing a connection that isn’t there.

What рот does have is a job you have been practising since Chapter 3: it is what makes говорить possible. You met г as Greek gamma on говорить’s very first line; here is the mouth that has been saying it ever since.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “рот” — one syllable, masculine
- the honest dead end — “no English cousin, only рыть, ‘to dig’”
- “рот, говорить” — the mouth, and what it has been doing since Chapter 3

Before you move on

Say “mouth,” with its gender. (Рот — **masculine**.) Is it related to English *mouth*? (Нo — separate Germanic root, no shared ancestor.) What is its own best guess of an origin? (Рыть, “to dig” — a snout rooting the ground.) Which Chapter 3 verb does the mouth make possible, and what letter did that verb first teach you? (Говорить; the letter г, Greek gamma.)

9.4 глаз — “eye,” the word for the eye that isn’t the word for the eye

The last of four face words, and the strangest story in the chapter: Russian’s everyday word for “eye” is not the word Indo-European gave it for “eye” at all.

You’ll want to know first — глаз

глаз — *glaz* — eye. Masculine.

Consonant-final, masculine, closing the chapter’s four with the same pattern that opened it in Chapter 6.

*(Tempting, on the page, to link this to English **glass** — the spellings even rhyme. Resist it: they trace to two different PIE roots and are not cousins. Its real story is stranger than that coincidence.)*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Every other body word in this chapter kept its ancient Indo-European name. Глаз did not. Глаз began in Old Russian as ***glazъ**, “a ball, a glass bead, a smooth round stone” — PIE ***g^(h)el-**, “round.” Starting around the sixteenth century it spread as slang for “eyeball,” then simply “eye,” and it **completely displaced** the true inherited word.

That older word was **око** (plural **очи**) — PIE ***h₃ók^ws**, the actual, secure cousin of English **eye** itself, the same root behind Latin **oculus** (→ **ocular**, **monocle**) and Greek **ophthalmós**. **Око** still exists, but only in poetry and set phrases now. Its one everyday survivor is hiding in plain sight: **очки**, “eyeglasses,” is built directly on **очи** — literally “**little eyes**.” So the word that means *eye* in Russian today is a Slavic upstart; the word that is actually your cousin only shows up when you put spectacles on.

This is Chapter 3’s **видеть** completed at last: the organ that does the seeing turns out to have replaced its own name, while the verb for *seeing* stayed put the whole time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “глаз” — masculine, and not related to English *glass*

- the evicted word — “око, очи — the real cousin of *eye*”
- where it hides — “очки, ‘little eyes’”
- the whole face — “ухо, нос, рот, глаз”

Before you move on

Say “eye,” with its gender. (Глаз — **masculine**.) What did глаз originally mean, and what word did it push out? (“**R**ound **o**bject, **b**all”; it displaced око.) Where does the true inherited eye-word survive today? (Очки, “glasses” — literally “little eyes.”) Name all four face words this chapter taught, in order. (Ухо, нос, рот, глаз.) Which Chapter 3 verb does the eye make possible, and what sound-swap did that verb teach in its *I* form? (Видеть; д → ж, as in вижу.)

Chapter 10

Heart

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name the heart in Russian, pronounce its silent letter correctly, and name its cousins across three other languages.*

A one-lesson chapter closing the tranche on сердце, the surest cognate in the book: the reader produces the word with its silent д, reads the new letter ц, names heart, cor and kardía as its cousins, and closes by naming любить as the verb the heart does — the last of Chapter 5’s atoms to be rescued.

10.1 сердце — “heart,” the surest cousin in this book

One more letter, one silent consonant, and then the tightest Indo-European cognate set this book will show you.

You’ll want to know first — сердце

сердце — *sérdtse* — heart. Neuter.

Ends in -це, a spelling variant of -o/-e forced by the letter before it — still Chapter 6’s neuter row. Stress on the front: *SYÉRT-se*. And listen closely: the д is not pronounced at all. Four consonants in a row would be unsayable, so Russian drops the middle one in speech — write **сердце**, say *sérts-e*.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Cyrillic.*) One new letter: **ц**.

- **ц** = “**ts**,” the sound at the end of English *cats*. No Latin look-alike to trip over — it simply hasn’t been in your way until now.

с, е, р, д, е you already have.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

сердце is Indo-European **kerd-*, and few roots in this book have travelled so far with so little disguise. English **heart** is the same word. Latin **cor**, genitive **cordis**, gave English **cordial** (“heartfelt”), **courage** (from the heart), and — by a long and surprising road through “to learn by heart” — **record**. Greek **kardía** gave **cardiac** and **cardiology**. Say *sérdtse*, *heart*, *cor*, *kardía* in a row and the family resemblance needs no proof.

It is fitting that the book’s most secure cousin is also the organ Chapter 5 gave a verb to: **любить**, with its inserted **л**, is what the **сердце** does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**сердце**” — silent **д**, *SYÉRT-se*
- the new letter — “**ц** says ts, as in cats”
- “heart, cor, kardía” — one root, three more languages
- all five body words — “**ухо, нос, рот, глаз, сердце**”
- “**Я люблю**” — the verb the heart does

Before you move on

Say “heart,” with its gender, and pronounce it correctly. (**Сердце** — **neuter** — *sérts-e*, the **д** silent.) What sound does **ц** make? (**Ts**, as in *cats*.) Name three English words that share its root, beyond *heart* itself. (**Cordial, courage, record** — from Latin *cor/cordis*; or **cardiac**, from Greek *kardía*.) Which Chapter 5 verb is what the heart does? (**Любить**, “to love.”)

Pronunciation & Cyrillic Reference

A **reference**, not a chapter — a place to look things up. You are *not* meant to read this before the lessons: the lessons teach reading through real words, introducing each letter as a word needs it. This page gathers the system in one spot. Full letter-by-letter decomposition (components + stroke order) lives in the machine-readable Cyrillic script reference.

The one thing that trips everyone: false friends

Cyrillic descends, like the Latin and Greek alphabets, from the Greek alphabet — so some letters are shared, but others look identical to Latin letters and say something completely different. These four cause 90% of beginner misreadings:

- **Cyrillic: В**
looks like Latin...: B
actually says: v
mnemonic: Greek *beta* drifted to a “v” sound
- **Cyrillic: Р**
looks like Latin...: P
actually says: r
mnemonic: Greek *rho*
- **Cyrillic: С**
looks like Latin...: C
actually says: s
mnemonic: Greek *sigma* (a “c” that hisses)
- **Cyrillic: Н**
looks like Latin...: H
actually says: n
mnemonic: Greek *eta* / Latin N with a level bar

Two vowels also mislead: *y* looks like Latin *y* but says “oo”; *x* looks like Latin *x* but says a raspy “kh.”

The letters, grouped by how they behave

- **Same look, same sound:** а (a), е (ye), к (k), м (m), о (o), т (t).
- **False friends** (look Latin, sound different): в (v), р (r), с (s), н (n), у (oo), х (kh).
- **Greek-shaped:** г (g, gamma Γ), д (d, delta Δ), л (l, lambda Λ), п (p, pi Π), ф (f, phi Φ).
- **Sounds English writes with two letters:** ж (zh, as in *measure*), ч (ch), ш (sh), щ (shch), ц (ts), ю (yu), я (ya), ё (yo).
- **The vowel English hasn’t got:** ы (yery-vowel) — not the *ee* of и, but a tighter sound made with the tongue **drawn back**. Say English *ill*, then say it again with your tongue pulled towards your throat. It is the single hardest Russian vowel for an English speaker, and it carries real meaning: ты (*you*) and вы (*you*, formal) both turn on it.
- **The two signs** — ъ (hard sign) and ь (soft sign) — spell *no sound of their own*; they only tell you how to pronounce the consonant before them (ь softens it).

Two rules that make you sound native

- **Stress is unmarked and it matters.** Russian never prints its stress accent, but stress governs the vowels — so you learn each word *with* its stress. (This reference marks it with an acute, *privét*, but real text won’t.)
- **Unstressed о → “a” (akanye).** An о not under stress reduces toward an *a*-ish sound: спасибо is said “spa-SEE-ba,” хорошо as “kha-ra-SHO.”

Sound ids used in the lessons

The lessons' **sounds**: frontmatter points here: **cyrillic-false-friends** (the table above), **stress-unmarked** and **o-reduction** (the two rules), **e-ye** (**е** carries a *y*-glide), **zh-sound** (ж), **b-vs-v** (б vs в), **silent-v** (the dropped в in **здравствуй**те), **syllable-drop** (spoken contractions like *pa-ZHAL-sta*), **a-clear** / **a-father** (the pure *a*).

Russian in the Slavic family

Slavic is a branch of **Indo-European**, so Russian is a distant cousin of English, Latin, and Sanskrit — which is why its deepest words (**нет** ← **ne*, **есть** “is” ← the same root as English *is*) line up with words you already own. Cyrillic itself was built in the 9th century from Greek letters (plus a few invented for Slavic sounds Greek lacked) to write Old Church Slavonic — which is why so many letters are Greek in disguise.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

брат *brat*

brother — masculine, one soft sign away from a verb you already know, and this time it really is your English cousin

Introduced in Chapter 7.

брать *brat'*

to take — English bear, and a partner from a completely different root

Introduced in Chapter 5.

быть *byt'*

to be — and the one tense in which Russian refuses to say it

Introduced in Chapter 3.

чай *chai*

tea — masculine, regular this time, and the overland twin of кофе's sea route

Introduced in Chapter 6.

читать *chítát'*

to read — and why Russian has no separate way to say I am reading

Introduced in Chapter 4.

да *da*

yes (da)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

друг *drug*

friend (male, or unspecified) — masculine, and the reason you own ты at all

Introduced in Chapter 7.

думать *dúmat'*

to think — and the fact that shapes every Russian verb you will ever meet

Introduced in Chapter 4.

глаз *glaz*

eye — masculine, and the word that quietly evicted Russian's inherited word for eye

Introduced in Chapter 9.

говорить *govorít'*

to speak — one new letter, and a false friend worth killing early
Introduced in Chapter 3.

идти *idtí*

to go — the one-way verb, and a past tense from a different root entirely
Introduced in Chapter 3.

как вас зовут? *kak vas zovút*

what's your name? — literally 'HOW do they call you?', not 'what'
Introduced in Chapter 2.

хлеб *khleb*

bread — masculine, and not a Slavic word at all
Introduced in Chapter 6.

кофе *kófe*

coffee — masculine, the one exception worth meeting on purpose
Introduced in Chapter 6.

любить *lyubít'*

to love, and to like — English love itself, with a letter that appears from nowhere
Introduced in Chapter 5.

меня зовут... *menyá zovút*

my name is... — literally 'they call me', with no word for 'my' and no word for 'name'
Introduced in Chapter 2.

нос *nos*

nose — masculine, and the same word as English nose and Latin nasus
Introduced in Chapter 9.

нет *nyet*

no (nyet)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

очень приятно *óchen priyátno*

pleased to meet you — literally 'very pleasant', and a cousin of English FRIEND
Introduced in Chapter 2.

писать *pisát'*

to write — one new letter, and the one stress mistake you must not make
Introduced in Chapter 4.

подруга *podrúga*

friend (female) — feminine, and друг with a prefix and an ending stitched on
Introduced in Chapter 7.

помогать *pomogát'*

to help — built on can, which is English may and might
Introduced in Chapter 5.

понимать *ponimát'*

to understand — literally to take hold of, which is what comprehend means too
Introduced in Chapter 4.

пожалуйста *pozhalusta*

please / you're welcome (pozhalusta)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

привет *privét*

hi / hello (privét — informal)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

рот *rot*

mouth — masculine, and this time the resemblance to English is not there to trust

Introduced in Chapter 9.

семья *sem'yá*

family — feminine, and an unexpected cousin of the English word home

Introduced in Chapter 8.

сердце *sérdtse*

heart — neuter, a silent letter, and one of the surest cognates in the entire

Indo-European family

Introduced in Chapter 10.

сестра *sestrá*

sister — feminine, brat's other half, and a cognate just as secure

Introduced in Chapter 7.

спасибо *spasíbo*

thank you (spasíbo)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

спрашивать *spráshivat'*

to ask a question — the verb behind the question you have asked since Chapter 2

Introduced in Chapter 5.

ты, вы *ty, vy*

you (informal) and you (formal) — the split English threw away

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ухо *úkho*

ear — neuter, the first word Russian gives its third gender, and a word-for-word

cousin of the English ear

Introduced in Chapter 9.

видеть *vídet'*

to see — the root behind both vision and wisdom

Introduced in Chapter 3.

вода *vodá*

water — feminine, and the first noun in this book, so it also teaches how every

Russian noun announces itself

Introduced in Chapter 6.

я *ya*

I — one letter, and one of the oldest words in Europe

Introduced in Chapter 2.

здравствуйте *zdrástvuyte*

hello (zdrástvuyte — formal / polite)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

жить *zhít'*

to live — and the English word that used to mean 'alive'

Introduced in Chapter 3.

знать *znát'*

to know — the same root as English know, and the sentence you will use most

Introduced in Chapter 3.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 2

2.1 *Why plural **Вы** became polite*

Which Russian form is safest with an adult when you are unsure?

2.2 *Why Russian asks how, not what*

Which language in this comparison asks what instead of how?

2.3 *Chapter 2 practice — run the exchange*

Turn **Как вас зовут?** into the form you use with one friend.

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 2

2.1 *Why plural **ВЫ** became polite*

Answer: **ВЫ**

Also accepted: vy

2.2 *Why Russian asks how, not what*

Answer: English

2.3 *Chapter 2 practice — run the exchange*

Answer: Как тебя зовут?

Also accepted: Kak tebya zovut?; Как тебя зовут; Kak tebya zovut

A note on sources

Etymologies are traced against standard comparative sources for Slavic and Indo-European, and every English cousin claimed here is one the evidence actually supports. Where a resemblance is only a resemblance, the text says so rather than quietly banking it.

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

B

bread — masculine, and not a Slavic word at all хлеб (khleb)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 41

brother — masculine, one soft sign away from a verb you already know, and this time it really is your English cousin брат (brat)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 49

C

coffee — masculine, the one exception worth meeting on purpose кофе (kófe)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 41

E

ear — neuter, the first word Russian gives its third gender, and a word-for-word cousin of the English ear ухо (úkho)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 9, p. 57

eye — masculine, and the word that quietly evicted Russian's inherited word for eye глаз (glaz)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 9, p. 57

Eyes, Ears, Mouth, and Nose

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 57

F

Family

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 55

family — feminine, and an unexpected cousin of the English

word home семья (sem'yá)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 8, p. 55

Friend and Siblings

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 49

friend (female) — feminine, and друг with a prefix and an ending

stitched on подруга (podrúga)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 7, p. 49

friend (male, or unspecified) — masculine, and the reason you

own ты at all друг (drug)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 49

G

Greetings and courtesy

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

Heart

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 63

heart — neuter, a silent letter, and one of the surest cognates in the entire Indo-European family сердце (sértse)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 63

hello (zdrávstvuyte — formal / polite) здравствуйте (zdrávstvuyte)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

hi / hello (privét — informal) привет (privét)

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

I

I — one letter, and one of the oldest words in Europe я (ya)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

Introducing yourself

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 7

M

mouth — masculine, and this time the resemblance to English is

not there to trust рот (rot)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 9, p. 57

my name is... — literally 'they call me', with no word for 'my'

and no word for 'name' меня зовут... (menyá zovút)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 7

N

no (nyet) нет (nyet)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

nose — masculine, and the same word as English nose and Latin

nasus нос (nos)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 9, p. 57

P

please / you're welcome (pozhálusta) пожалуйста (pozhálusta)

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

pleased to meet you — literally 'very pleasant', and a cousin of

English FRIEND очень приятно (óchen priyátno)

Chapter 2, p. 7

S

sister — feminine, brat's other half, and a cognate just as

secure сестра (sestrá)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 49

Six Verbs, and the One You Never Say

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 13

T

Taking, Asking, Helping, Loving

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 33

tea — masculine, regular this time, and the overland twin of

кофе's sea route чай (chai)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 41

- thank you** (spasíbo) спасибо (spasíbo)
explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1
- to ask a question — the verb behind the question you have asked since Chapter 2** спрашивать (spráshivat')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 5, p. 33
- to be — and the one tense in which Russian refuses to say it** быть (byt')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13
- to go — the one-way verb, and a past tense from a different root entirely** идти (idtí)
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13
- to help — built on can, which is English may and might** помогать (pomogát')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 33
- to know — the same root as English know, and the sentence you will use most** знать (znat')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13
- to live — and the English word that used to mean 'alive'** жить (zhít')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13
- to love, and to like — English love itself, with a letter that appears from nowhere** любить (lyubít')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 33
- to read — and why Russian has no separate way to say I am reading** читать (chítát')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 25
- to see — the root behind both vision and wisdom** видеть (vídet')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13
- to speak — one new letter, and a false friend worth killing early** говорить (govorít')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13
- to take — English bear, and a partner from a completely different root** брать (brat')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 33
- to think — and the fact that shapes every Russian verb you will ever meet** думать (dúmat')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 25
- to understand — literally to take hold of, which is what comprehend means too** понимать (ponimát')
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 25
- to write — one new letter, and the one stress mistake you must not make** писать (pisát')
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 25

V

Verbs of the Mind and the Page

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 25

W

Water, Coffee, Tea, and Bread

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 41

water — **feminine, and the first noun in this book, so it also teaches how every Russian noun announces itself** вода (vodá)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 41

what's your name? — **literally 'HOW do they call you?', not 'what'** как вас зовут? (kak vas zovút)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 7

Why plural вы became polite

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 2, p. 7

Why Russian asks *how*, not *what*

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 7

Y

yes (da) да (da)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

you (informal) and you (formal) — **the split English threw away** ты, вы (ty, vy)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

Other

б and д — **letters that hide nothing**

script and writing topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

в and р — **writing the two great false friends**

script and writing topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

е and т — **the last two letters of привет**

script and writing topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

п and и — **filling in привет**

script and writing topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

с and н — **the last two false friends**

script and writing topic; Chapter 1, p. 1